Investigation report

Paywall to purchase: where the funnel drops

Where do users drop from viewing a paywall to starting checkout and purchasing?

Data

Authorized PocketToons SQLite fixture
April–September 2026 UTC

Snapshot

2026-09-30 23:59:59 UTC metadata
Build 3a0dbed21d2f45958aefa2887a0cadd8

Run

Independent
2026-11-09
11 read-only checks

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How to read this report

- Check numbers refer to the JSONL evidence files.
- The approved funnel counts paywall views; patterns do not establish causes.

Terms used in this report

Term	Meaning
Checkout	A checkout event explicitly linked to a paywall.
Purchase	A valid successful charge linked through checkout; later refunds do not remove it.

01. Chapter

The answer

01

The largest measured drop is before checkout: 3,824 of 7,221 paywall views (53.0%) have no linked checkout. Another 1,804 (25.0% of views) reach checkout without a linked purchase; 1,593 (22.1%) reach a purchase (checks 3–5).

- For May–September, 59.5% of views had no linked checkout and 28.1% reached checkout without a linked purchase.
- Subscription accounts for 2,746 of 3,146 later no-checkout views and 1,292 of 1,484 later checkout-without-purchase views (check 7).
- Prioritize link instrumentation and the subscription journey. Missing links prevent interpreting every gap as abandonment.

Data snapshot 2026-09-30 23:59:59 UTC metadata · build 3a0dbed21d2f45958aefa2887a0cadd8 · 11 read-only checks

02. Chapter

How we investigated

02

What data we used

- Complete view months [2026-04-01, 2026-10-01), UTC; linked later events credited to view month with no fixed conversion window.
- Approved paywall_funnel v1.0 uses one paywall view as the unit, counting multiple linked checkouts or attempts at most once. A later refund does not undo a purchase.
- Gold monthly funnel, Silver detail and Bronze checkout links; dataset metadata snapshot 2026-09-30 23:59:59 UTC is not a verified hash.

Investigation path

- Baseline and coverage: checks 1–6, 9–11.
- One hypothesis round: product and time decomposition (checks 3, 5, 7) and linked payment attempt classification (check 8).
- Stop: stage patterns are quantified, but available telemetry does not establish behavioral or technical causes.

03. Chapter

What happened

03

The movement

Month	Views	Checkout	Purchase	View to checkout	Checkout to purchase
Apr	1,935	1,257	937	65.0%	74.5%
May	1,088	455	160	41.8%	35.2%
Jun	1,023	399	102	39.0%	25.6%
Jul	1,069	428	140	40.0%	32.7%
Aug	1,026	421	102	41.0%	24.2%
Sep	1,080	437	152	40.5%	34.8%

Who drove it

- April versus pooled May–September: paywall-to-checkout fell from 65.0% to 40.5%; checkout-to-purchase fell from 74.5% to 30.7%. Rates are event-weighted, not averages of monthly rates (check 5).
- Subscription rates fell from 66.3% to 39.4% at checkout and from 76.4% to 27.6% at purchase. PPV rates were 49.4% to 47.1%, and 46.1% to 46.1%, respectively (check 5). April is one month; September may have incomplete follow-up.

04. Chapter

Why it happened

04

- **Supported pattern:** more views lack a linked checkout (3,824) than reach checkout without a linked purchase (1,804), over the full period.
- **Supported pattern:** subscription represents 87.3% of later no-checkout views and 87.1% of later checkout-without-purchase views; product volume matters (check 7).
- **Payment failure explanation not supported by captured attempts:** all 1,292 later subscription checkouts without purchase have no linked non-refund attempt. Missing telemetry and behavior remain indistinguishable (check 8).

05. Chapter

Data quality and limits

05

Data quality

- Build 3a0dbed21d2f45958aefa2887a0cadd8 succeeded 2026-11-09 11:16:56 UTC; all recorded reconciliation checks passed. Relevant current row counts match build counts; source content hashes were not recomputed (checks 2, 9, 10).
- Build registry SHA-256 57b21d...1227 differs from current registry 4b5b2f...5554. Both identify the funnel group as v1.0, but file equivalence was not established. Gold row definitions omit the funnel version; build metadata records it.
- There were 175 checkout events without paywall links and 56 of 1,725 in-app purchases without checkout links (3.2%), counted by their own event months. They cannot be assigned to paywall cohorts (check 5).
- All 7,221 paywall rows had distinct IDs and identified users; none had a flagged funnel exception. Implemented rules cannot detect every telemetry omission (checks 4, 6). The build records 13 reviewed payment corrections with unknown review time (check 2).

Limitations

- The approved metric counts events, not distinct people. Monthly distinct people by product appear in check 11 and can overlap across months and products.
- No causal experiment, checkout substep or abandonment reason was assessed. No linked attempt does not prove no attempt occurred.
- Link gaps, possible late follow-up, unverified current fingerprints and the registry hash mismatch limit precise interpretation.

06. Chapter

What to do next

06

- Audit paywall-to-checkout and checkout-to-transaction links against client, server and provider records, including retries and lags.
- Instrument checkout substeps and errors; investigate the May transition and subscription experience. Use controlled experiments to validate causes.
- Reconcile registry versions and verify source fingerprints, then repeat with a defined mature conversion window.

Appendix

Evidence appendix

A

Checks	Purpose
01–02	Inventory, metadata and build
03–05	Baseline, identity and product totals
06–08	Exceptions, stage decomposition and attempts
09–10	Build fingerprints and current row counts
11	Distinct-person descriptive variant